

The Cosmetic Rises to the Surface

All of the topics in Part One are actually only one. You can think about a subject for a long time, to the point of being possessed by it. Somehow you have a lot of ideas, but they do not seem explicitly connected; the logic linking them remains concealed from you. Yet you know deep down that all these are *the same* idea. Meanwhile, what Nietzsche calls *bildungsphilisters*,* or learned philistines, blue collars of the thinking business, tell you that you are spread out between fields; you reply that these disciplines are artificial and arbitrary, to no avail. Then you tell them that you are a limousine driver, and they leave you alone—you feel better because you do not identify with them, and thus you no longer need to be amputated to fit into the Procrustean bed of the disciplines. Finally, a little push and you see that it was all one single problem.

One evening I found myself at a cocktail party in Munich at the apartment of a former art historian who had more art books in its library than I thought existed. I stood drinking excellent Riesling in the spontaneously formed English-speaking corner of the apartment, in the hope of getting to a state where I would be able to start speaking my brand of fake German. One of the most insightful thinkers I know, the computer entrepreneur Yossi Vardi, prompted me to summarize “my idea” while standing on one leg. It was not too convenient to stand on one leg after a few glasses of perfumed Riesling, so I failed in my improvisation. The next day I experienced staircase wit. I jumped out of bed with the following idea: *the cosmetic and the Platonic rise naturally to the surface*. This is a simple extension of the problem of knowledge. It is simply that one side of Eco’s library, the one we never see, has the property of being ignored. This is also the problem of silent evidence. It is why we do not see Black Swans: we worry about those that happened, not those that may happen but did not. It is why we Platonify, liking known schemas and well-organized knowledge—to the point of blindness to reality. It is why we fall for the problem of induction, why we *confirm*. It is why those who “study” and fare well in school have a tendency to be suckers for the ludic fallacy.

And it is why we have Black Swans and never learn from their occurrence, because the ones that did not happen were too abstract. Thanks to Vardi, I now belonged to the club of single-idea people.

We love the tangible, the confirmation, the palpable, the real, the visible, the concrete, the known, the seen, the vivid, the visual, the social, the